

Sharps and flats

Sharps and flats are used to indicate a raised or lowered note. Sharps raise a note to the note immediately above it on the keyboard. Flats lower a note to the note immediately below it on the keyboard. Flats lower a note to the note immediately below it.

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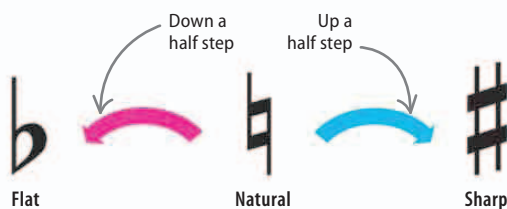
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What are sharps and flats?

Sharps and flats are symbols that indicate when a note is raised or lowered by a half step to the note immediately above or below it on the keyboard. Notes that are not sharp or flat are called naturals. Sharps raise naturals by one half step, and flats lower naturals by one half step.



◀ Symbols

These are the symbols for flats, naturals, and sharps. Naturals move down a half step to become flats or up a half step to become sharps.

Look at the black keys

A black key on the keyboard can be called either sharp or flat. If a white key moves up a half step to a note, that note is written as a sharp. If it moves a half step down, the note is written as a flat.

This note is called D $\sharp$ because it is one half step up from D, but it can also be called E $\flat$ because it is one half step down from E.

G moves up a half step to become G $\sharp$.

B moves down a half step to become B $\flat$.

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▽ Sharps and flats on black keys

The black keys are sharps or flats depending on whether the white keys are below or above them.

